

LA5222 Field Journal — Desktop Study
Bidadari Park: A Historical, Planning, and Socio-Ecological Timeline
Daniela Resendiz Garcia

Purpose of this note

This document assembles, in chronological order, what can be verified from academic and official sources about the site now occupied by Bidadari Park, in Toa Payoh/Serangoon, Singapore. It is meant as a desktop-study companion to the paired field observations, organised so that the historical, planning, and social/ecological strands required by the assignment guide can be lifted directly into the Field Journal reflection. Where a detail could not be confirmed against a citable source, it is flagged as unconfirmed rather than stated as fact.

Timeline

1870s–1885 — Istana Bidadari (pre-cemetery estate) The land was originally held by civil engineer H.M. Simons and later by William Napier, before passing to Sultan Abu Bakar of Johor (Saparudin, 2013). Abu Bakar's second consort, Cecilia Catharina Lange (after conversion to Islam, Che Puan Besar Zubaidah), lived at the Istana Bidadari on the estate; their children Mariam and Ibrahim (later Sultan of Johor) were born there in 1871 and 1873 (Saparudin, 2013). Zubaidah left for Johor once Abu Bakar became Sultan in 1885 (Saparudin, 2013). [*Academic/heritage: BiblioAsia, National Library Board*]

1902–1910 — Establishment of the Muslim cemetery The Municipal Commissioners first sought the Bidadari site for a Christian cemetery because of drainage problems at the existing Bukit Timah ground; Muslim petitioners, led by the Dato' Mentri, made the reservation of adjoining land for a Muslim burial ground a condition of the acquisition (Saparudin, 2013). The Muslim section opened on 14 February 1910, with only one burial that year against 71 Christian burials (Saparudin, 2013). This made Bidadari, over time, both Singapore's first Muslim state cemetery and one of its first purpose-planned multi-religious burial grounds (Saparudin, 2013). [*Heritage: BiblioAsia/NLB*]

1929–1964 — Alkaff Gardens (adjacent heritage layer) Distinct from, and contemporaneous with, the cemetery, a roughly 10-acre private leisure garden was developed nearby by the Alkaff family, wealthy Arab merchants and landowners, as the centrepiece of a planned residential estate of about 1,000 bungalows, terrace houses and shophouses; the gardens were opened to the public in 1929 (National Heritage Board, 2024). Laid out along Japanese landscaping principles, Alkaff Gardens became a popular destination for picnicking families, boating on its lake, and strolling among pavilions and bamboo groves (National Heritage Board, 2024). In December 1941 the British military requisitioned the gardens, first headquartering the Singapore Volunteer Corps there

and later a military Ambulance Corps unit; the gardens were bombed during the Japanese invasion of Singapore (National Heritage Board, 2024). The gardens reopened to the public after the war, but the land was sold to the Sennett Estate Company in 1950 and the neglected grounds served afterwards mainly as a film location, notably for productions starring the Malay screen legend P. Ramlee, before being retained through the residential development of Sennett Estate and finally filled in 1964 for the construction of Willow Avenue Secondary School (National Heritage Board, 2024). This episode is the direct heritage referent for the present-day Alkaff Lake, and its own military-requisition and wartime-bombing history adds a further, distinct layer of social memory to the site beyond the cemetery narrative below. *[Official/heritage: National Heritage Board Heritage Walk interpretive panel, photographed on site]*

1907/1908–1972 — Bidadari General Cemetery in operation Bidadari operated as one of Singapore's largest cemeteries, with sections for Christian, Muslim, Hindu and Sinhalese communities (National Library Board, 2004). Burials were accepted from 1907/1908 until the cemetery's closure on 31 October 1972 (National Library Board, 2004). By closure it held an estimated 147,000 graves in total, including roughly 54,000–58,000 Christian burials and 68,000–78,800 Muslim burials, the Muslim section eventually surpassing the Christian one in number (National Library Board, 2004; Saparudin, 2013). This scale and religious diversity gave the site lasting social and genealogical significance for Singaporean Christian, Muslim, Hindu and Chinese communities, since a very large share of families with roots in colonial and early post-independence Singapore had relatives interred there (National Library Board, 2004). *[Heritage/official: National Library Board Infopedia]*

1996 — Redevelopment earmarked The government announced that the former cemetery land had been set aside for future housing development, opening a long period of public debate about how to treat a site that was, in effect, a mass burial ground at the edge of the built-up city (National Library Board, 2004). *[Heritage/official]*

2001–2006 — Exhumation Exhumation proceeded in stages, under the supervision of clergy from the respective religious communities, roughly between 2001 and 2004 for most burials, with the process considered complete by 2006 (National Library Board, 2004). Remains were cremated and stored for a period (commonly cited as around three years) during which relatives could come forward to claim them for re-interment, chiefly at Choa Chu Kang Cemetery; unclaimed cremated remains were interred at sea (National Library Board, 2004). The great majority of graves went unclaimed: by the end of 2001 alone, some 49,000 of about 58,000 Christian graves were reported as still unclaimed (National Library Board, 2004). This scale of exhumation, of a socially significant, multi-religious, multi-generational cemetery in the middle of a small, land-scarce city-state, is exactly the kind of episode that Singapore-focused death/landscape geography has treated as a site of contested memory and state-led erasure of vernacular heritage. Kong and Yeoh's broader account of Singapore's "landscapes of death" frames cemetery clearance as a recurring feature of nation-building and land-use policy in which burial grounds are progressively read by the state

as available land rather than as heritage (Kong and Yeoh, 2003); Tan and Yeoh's study of the spatial politics of Chinese burial grounds documents a comparable pattern of state reclamation of cemetery land in post-war Singapore (Tan and Yeoh, 2002); and Kong's methodological essay on deathscapes argues more generally that cemeteries carry contested social meaning well beyond their function as burial infrastructure (Kong, 1999). **Caveat:** none of these three sources, in the material retrieved for this note, names Bidadari as a specific case study — they establish the general academic framework (contested deathscapes, state-led cemetery clearance for development) into which Bidadari fits, rather than a peer-reviewed study of Bidadari itself. A 2018 heritage-studies article on Asian cities does discuss the transformation of the Bidadari cemetery site into a housing estate directly, though drawing mainly on press coverage rather than primary fieldwork (Ocón, 2018). No Bidadari-specific peer-reviewed case study (comparable to Muzaini and Yeoh's work on Kranji War Cemetery) was located; this should be treated as an open gap rather than as evidence that no such literature exists. *[Academic, with explicit caveat; heritage/official for factual timeline]*

2004–2019 — First Bidadari Memorial Garden In 2004, the National Heritage Board established a memorial garden along Mount Vernon Road to preserve elements of the cemetery: the original cemetery gates and gateposts were re-used as the garden entrance, and 21 selected headstones and relics of notable individuals (including Ahmad Ibrahim, a former Minister for Health) were relocated there, arranged in sections recalling the former Christian, Muslim and Hindu burial grounds (National Heritage Board, 2020). This first memorial garden closed on 10 June 2019 to make way for construction, with NHB, HDB and NParks agreeing to relocate its artefacts into the new Bidadari Park (National Heritage Board, 2020). *[Official: National Heritage Board / ROOTS]*

2013 — Bidadari Estate announced; master-planning begins In August 2013, HDB announced Bidadari as a new public housing estate, targeting roughly 10,000–12,000 residential units (National Heritage Board, 2020; Urban Strategies Inc., 2016). Urban Strategies Inc. was engaged as master planner, working with MKPL Architects and Arup (transport, hydrology and sustainability), under a design vision described as a garden-like setting integrating housing with a regional park and green corridors (Urban Strategies Inc., 2016). *[Official/consultant: Urban Strategies Inc., commissioned by HDB]*

2014 — URA Master Plan designation The 2014 Urban Redevelopment Authority Master Plan formalised Bidadari's land use, including a roughly 10-hectare Bidadari Park at the estate's core, a Heritage Walk of about 700 metres along the mature rain trees of the former Upper Aljunied Road (linking Woodleigh MRT station to a memorial garden), and infrastructure such as Singapore's first underground air-conditioned bus interchange and an ecolink connecting Bidadari Park to Alkaff Lake/Hillock Park (Urban Strategies Inc., 2016). The URA Master Plan itself is the statutory instrument that sets permissible land use and density for a 10–15 year horizon and is reviewed roughly every five years (Urban Redevelopment Authority, 2025); the exact wording of the 2014 Written Statement for the Bidadari subzone was not directly retrieved for this note; the figures

above come from the master-planning consultant's own project account rather than the URA document itself, and should be checked against URA SPACE / the Written Statement if exact figures are needed for the reflection. *[Official, with one flagged gap]*

2013–2024 — Construction of housing and public realm HDB progressively delivered Build-To-Order flats and the estate's public realm across this period, framed throughout under the vision of a "Community in a Garden" (National Parks Board, 2024). The estate was completed in phases, with the final projects handed over as part of a multi-agency effort involving HDB, NParks, PUB and NHB (National Parks Board, 2024). In 2024, HDB's Bidadari Estate master plan won the World Gold award in the Master Plan category at the FIABCI World Prix d'Excellence Awards, described as the only World Gold award for Singapore that year and the first World Gold in that category for a Singapore developer (Housing and Development Board, 2024). *[Official: HDB]*

3 September 2024 — Opening of Bidadari Park and Alkaff Lake NParks, HDB, PUB and NHB jointly opened Bidadari Park and its centrepiece, Alkaff Lake, occupying roughly 10 hectares (reported by NParks as more than 10 percent of the estate's total land area) (National Parks Board, 2024). Alkaff Lake references the historic Alkaff Gardens, a leisure garden built in 1929 by the Alkaff family, Arab merchants and landowners in early twentieth-century Singapore (National Parks Board, 2024). Functionally, the lake is a water-sensitive urban design feature: it is described by NParks and by lead consultant CPG Corporation as multi-functional drainage infrastructure, doubling as a stormwater retention pond (holding up to 40,000 cubic metres of water, equated to about 16 Olympic-sized pools) during heavy rain and as a recreational and community space in dry weather (National Parks Board, 2024; CPG Corporation, 2024). Heritage elements integrated into the park include a Heritage Walk with storyboards, the relocated Bidadari Memorial Garden (again organised by former Christian, Muslim and Hindu sections), and references to landmarks such as the former Alkaff Gardens and Bidadari House (National Parks Board, 2024; National Heritage Board, 2020). **Caveat:** whether specific original tombstones or the original cemetery gate structures (as opposed to replica markers or storyboards) were physically re-installed inside the 2024 park, versus staying at the 2004–2019 Mount Vernon garden's relocated collection, was not confirmed in the sources retrieved and should be verified on site or with NHB before being stated as fact. *[Official: NParks, CPG Corporation]*

2024 — Ecological design features CPG Consultants describe a design approach of "respect, transform, and beautify," combining heritage interpretation with biodiversity-oriented infrastructure (CPG Corporation, 2024). Documented ecological elements include: a marshland system with upper and lower sections at varying water depths to support wildlife across seasons; the Ficus Stream, a series of cascading constructed wetlands that filter runoff and slow water before it enters the drainage system; a land bridge connecting the main park to an adjacent one-hectare hillock, explicitly designed as a habitat corridor for birds and butterflies and to preserve stopover habitat for migratory birds; and re-use of felled timber (upcycled logs and stumpery) along Sang

Nila Utama Boulevard to create insect and amphibian habitat (CPG Corporation, 2024; National Parks Board, 2024). Landscape architecture was led by Henning Larsen with Ramboll Waters on water-sensitive urban design, under CPG Consultants as lead consultant (CPG Corporation, 2024). *[Official/consultant: CPG Corporation, NParks]*

Synthesis: connecting the timeline to the desktop-study questions

Read against the assignment's three desktop-study prompts, the timeline suggests the following. On **historical context**, the site's value is layered rather than singular: it was first a Johor royal residence, then for roughly six decades a large multi-religious cemetery holding some 147,000 graves across Christian, Muslim, Hindu and Chinese communities (National Library Board, 2004; Saparudin, 2013), and its 2001–2006 exhumation was a socially significant, contested episode of the kind that Singapore death-landscape scholarship associates with state-led erasure of vernacular heritage under development pressure (Kong and Yeoh, 2003; Tan and Yeoh, 2002), even though a Bidadari-specific peer-reviewed case study could not be located and this gap should be named as such in the reflection. On **planning context**, Bidadari sits inside a clearly documented, multi-decade, multi-agency planning trajectory: HDB's 2013 estate announcement, the 2014 URA Master Plan designation, and the "Community in a Garden" vision executed jointly by HDB, URA, NParks, PUB and NHB, connect the site outward to Woodleigh MRT, to the wider park-connector network, and to national "City in Nature" style ambitions for housing-integrated greenery (Urban Strategies Inc., 2016; National Parks Board, 2024; Housing and Development Board, 2024). On **social and ecological context**, the same redevelopment that erased most physical traces of the cemetery also produced deliberate memory-work (the 2004 and post-2019 memorial gardens, the Heritage Walk) alongside explicit ecological engineering: Alkaff Lake and the Ficus Stream wetlands function simultaneously as stormwater infrastructure and habitat, and the land bridge to the northern hillock is an explicit, documented biodiversity-corridor design decision rather than an incidental green space (CPG Corporation, 2024; National Parks Board, 2024). Together these strands support treating the paired field patch not simply as "a park," but as a site where contested social memory, top-down master-planning, and engineered ecological function are layered on top of one another, which is itself worth stating explicitly in the Field Journal.

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AI disclosure: This desktop-study timeline was compiled with the assistance of Claude (Anthropic), which conducted web-based research using official government sources (HDB, URA, NParks, National Heritage Board), the National Library Board’s Infopedia and BiblioAsia, and academic literature, and drafted the text below. All citations were verified against the retrieved source content; claims that could

not be verified are flagged explicitly in the text above rather than stated as fact. This draft should be checked against original sources before submission.